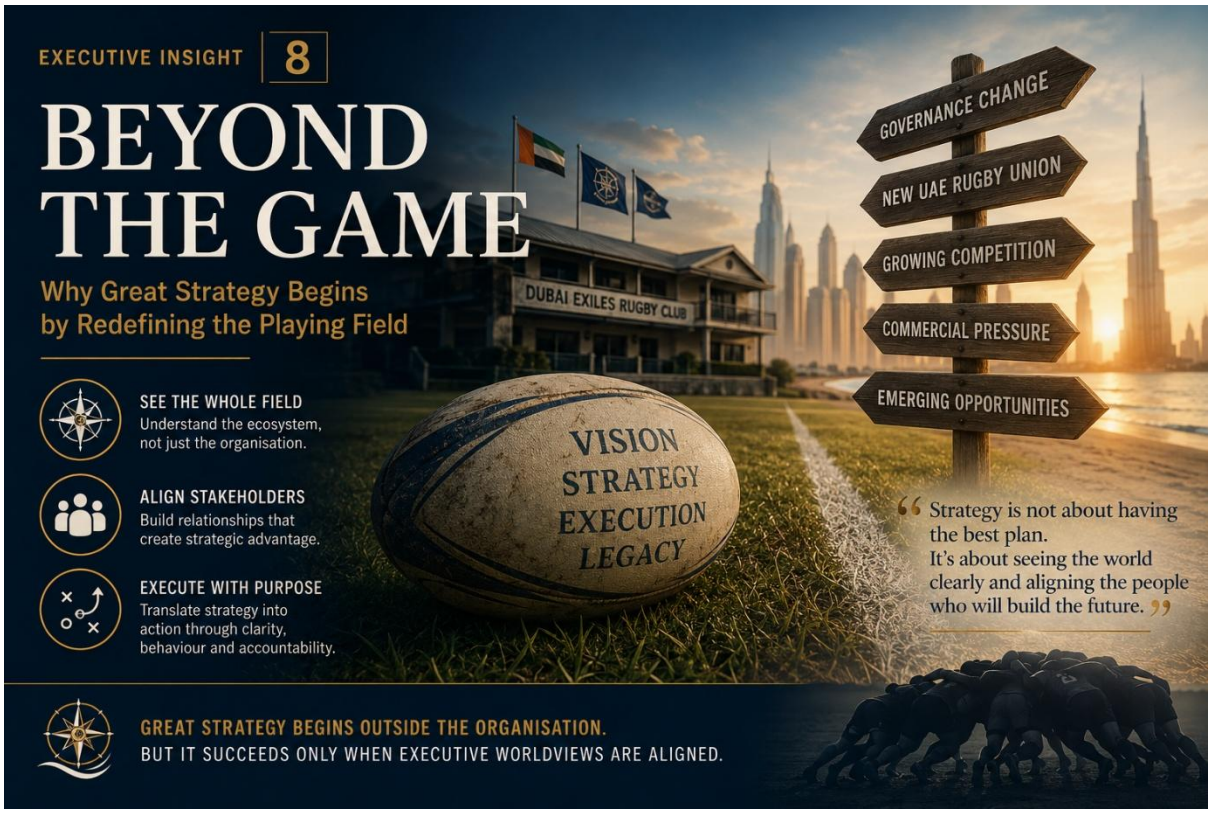




There is a temptation in every strategic planning exercise to begin by asking, What should we do next? It is an understandable instinct. Organisations exist to act, and strategy is often viewed as the process of determining which actions deserve priority. Yet over the years I have come to believe that this is rarely the right place to start.

The most successful strategic conversations begin with a different question altogether.

What game are we actually playing?

The distinction is subtle but profound. Organisations frequently assume that the environment in which they compete is largely stable and that their task is simply to improve their performance within it. They refine objectives, restructure operations and launch new initiatives, believing that better execution alone will secure future success. Occasionally that assumption proves correct.

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GEORGE KESSELAAR
PhD (UCT) | MBA (UCT)
www.aviewonchange.com
aviewonchange@gmail.com



More often, however, organisations discover that the rules of competition have already begun to change while they remain focused on improving performance within yesterday's game.

I encountered this lesson during a strategic planning engagement with one of the leading rugby organisations in the Arabian Gulf. The assignment appeared straightforward. The committee wanted a strategic framework that would guide the club's development over the coming seasons by clarifying its vision, defining strategic priorities and translating those priorities into practical initiatives. At first glance, it seemed no different from countless other strategic planning exercises undertaken by sporting organisations around the world.

The further we explored the organisation, however, the clearer it became that writing a strategy would not be enough.

Rugby throughout the Gulf was entering a period of unprecedented institutional change. The creation of the UAE Rugby Union would fundamentally reshape the governance of the sport, replacing long-established regional structures with a new national governing body. The continued commercial development of The Sevens complex was changing the economics of rugby by transforming what had once been purely sporting infrastructure into a broader commercial destination. At the same time, other clubs across the Emirates were strengthening their capabilities, attracting members and sponsors and establishing increasingly distinctive identities. Governments throughout the region were also beginning to invest more seriously in sport and youth development, creating opportunities that had scarcely existed only a few years earlier.

None of these developments originated within the club itself.

Yet every one of them would shape its future.

That observation fundamentally altered the nature of the engagement. The question was no longer how the organisation could become a better rugby club. The more important question became how it could remain relevant within an ecosystem that was itself being transformed.

Looking back, I realise that this was the moment the engagement shifted from strategic planning to strategic thinking.

Too often, organisations confuse the two. Strategic planning is concerned with producing a roadmap. Strategic thinking begins by questioning whether the map still represents the territory. It



requires leaders to step outside their own organisation and examine the broader institutional landscape that gives meaning to every strategic decision they make. Without that wider perspective, even the most carefully constructed strategic plans risk becoming increasingly disconnected from the realities they were intended to address.

That is why our first task was not to rewrite the club's vision or identify new initiatives. Instead, we sought to understand the competitive landscape within which the organisation operated. We examined the evolving governance of rugby across the Gulf, the relationships between regional and international bodies, the emergence of new competitors, the expectations of members and sponsors, and the wider forces that were reshaping the sport. The strategy would emerge from that understanding, not precede it.

It was a lesson that has remained with me ever since.

Great strategy rarely begins inside the organisation.

It begins by redefining the playing field upon which the organisation will compete.

Seeing the Whole Playing Field

As our understanding of the competitive environment deepened, it became increasingly apparent that the organisation's future would not be determined solely by the quality of its rugby. Its success would depend just as much on the quality of its relationships.

This is a lesson that extends well beyond sport.

Every organisation exists within an ecosystem of stakeholders whose interests, expectations and influence continually shape its strategic options. Customers, regulators, partners, suppliers, employees, governing bodies, investors and competitors all exert pressure on the choices organisations make. Yet strategic planning frequently treats these groups as external variables to be managed after the strategy has been formulated. Our experience suggested the opposite. Stakeholders should shape strategy from the outset because they define the environment in which strategy must ultimately succeed.

For that reason, one of our first priorities was to map the club's stakeholder landscape. Rather than viewing stakeholders simply as groups to communicate with, we sought to understand how each



would influence the club's future and how the club, in turn, needed to engage them. Committee members, players, sponsors, governing bodies and competing clubs each occupied a different position within the emerging rugby ecosystem. Each possessed different levels of influence, different expectations and different capacities either to accelerate or constrain the club's ambitions.

What emerged was a far richer understanding of strategy than the traditional notion of setting objectives.

For example, players and members represented far more than participants in the club's activities. They were ambassadors for its culture, contributors to its identity and, ultimately, the reason the club existed. Sponsors were not simply sources of revenue. They were strategic partners whose willingness to invest depended upon the clarity of the club's value proposition and its ability to demonstrate meaningful returns. The governing bodies responsible for rugby within the region were not merely regulators; they were collaborators whose evolving structures would influence opportunities for growth, player development and regional influence. Even competing clubs could no longer be viewed exclusively as rivals. As rugby expanded across the Gulf, collaboration between clubs became increasingly important in strengthening the sport itself, creating opportunities that no single organisation could achieve independently.

This broader perspective inevitably led us to another important question.

If the competitive environment was changing, what exactly was the organisation offering that distinguished it from everyone else?

Like many organisations, the club possessed a proud history, a respected reputation and a loyal community. Yet these qualities alone no longer guaranteed future success. Reputation is an inheritance; value propositions are choices. Organisations cannot rely indefinitely on what they have achieved in the past. They must continually redefine why they matter in the future.

This prompted one of the most important conversations of the entire engagement. Rather than asking how the club could become more successful, we asked what kind of organisation it wanted to become. The discussion gradually shifted away from winning trophies towards creating an environment that players, families, supporters and sponsors genuinely wanted to be part of. Success would certainly continue to be measured on the field, but it would also be reflected in the strength of the club's identity, the quality of its relationships and the experience it created for everyone



connected with it. This thinking ultimately informed a revised vision that emphasised building an appealing club environment, strengthening community and becoming a leading force within rugby through the quality of both its sporting and social experience.

In retrospect, this was perhaps the most significant outcome of the strategy process.

We did not simply produce a new strategic framework.

We helped the organisation redefine the game it believed it was playing.

That shift in perspective changed everything that followed. Once the club understood that its future depended upon creating a compelling value proposition rather than merely organising rugby matches, the strategic priorities became far clearer. Facilities, sponsorship, player recruitment, committee development and governance were no longer independent initiatives competing for attention. They became interconnected investments in a single strategic purpose: creating a club that people actively wanted to join, support and help build.

The strategy was no longer a collection of projects.

It had become a coherent story about the organisation's future

Building a Blueprint for Execution

One of the enduring frustrations of strategic planning is that organisations often mistake completion for progress.

A strategy is approved by the board, presented to stakeholders and circulated throughout the organisation. The planning process concludes with a sense of accomplishment, yet very little has actually changed. The organisation possesses a strategy, but it has not yet developed the capacity to execute it.

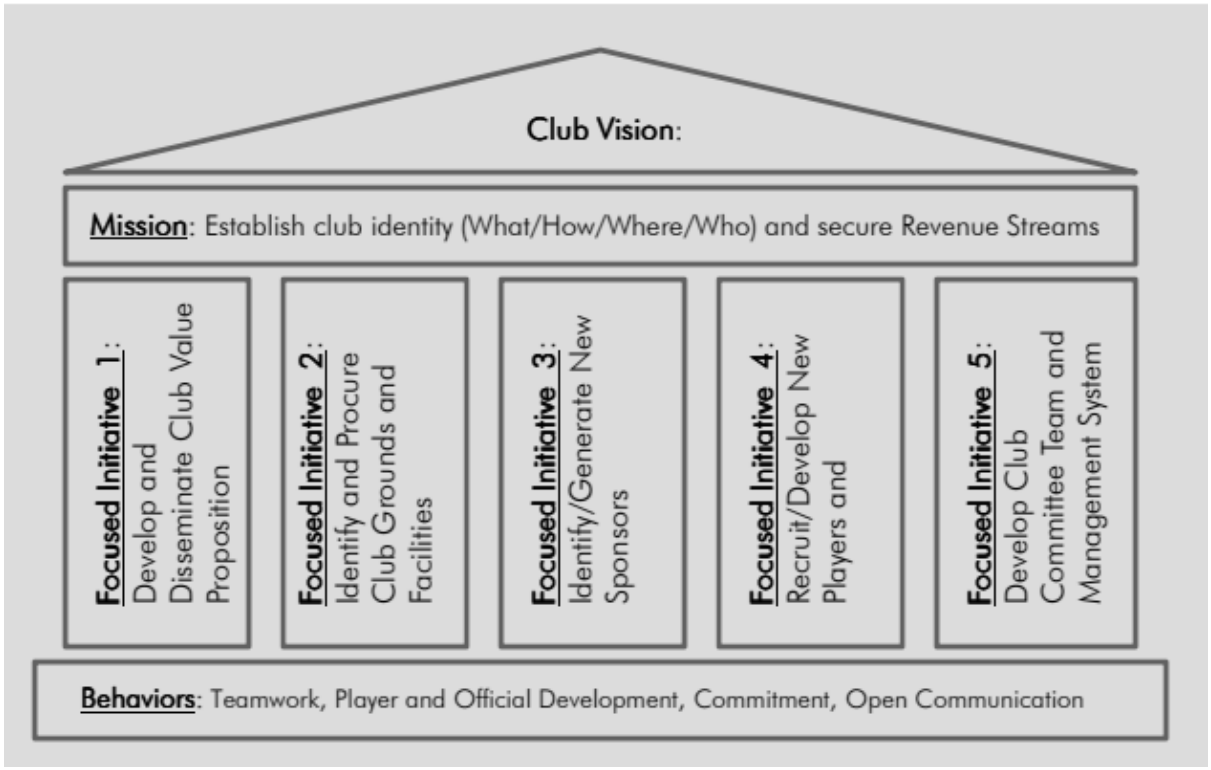
Over the years I have become convinced that this happens because many strategic plans answer only one question: What do we want to achieve? Far fewer answer the more difficult question: How will this organisation consistently behave if it is to realise that ambition?

That distinction became central to our work.



Having redefined the club's strategic direction and clarified its value proposition, the next challenge was to translate those aspirations into an integrated framework for execution. Rather than producing a lengthy strategic document filled with independent objectives, we wanted to create something that committee members could understand intuitively and use to guide everyday decisions. Strategy needed to become a practical management system rather than an annual planning exercise.

To achieve this, we adopted a simple but powerful metaphor.



A strategic framework, we argued, is much like the blueprint for constructing a building. Before construction begins, architects do not produce isolated drawings for foundations, plumbing, electrical systems and roofing. They first develop an integrated blueprint that demonstrates how every component contributes to a single structure. Only once that overall design is understood do the detailed plans begin to make sense. We believed organisations should approach strategy in exactly the same way.



This philosophy shaped the architecture of the framework we ultimately developed.

At its highest level sat a renewed vision that described the future identity of the club. Beneath that, the committee agreed upon a clear mission for the coming season, recognising that long-term aspirations required immediate priorities capable of focusing attention and resources. Supporting the mission were a small number of focused strategic initiatives that captured the essential areas requiring investment if the vision was to become reality. Rather than attempting to pursue dozens of unrelated projects, the framework concentrated the club's energy on a limited number of mutually reinforcing priorities, including clarifying the club's value proposition, strengthening facilities, securing sustainable sponsorship, developing players and building the capability of the committee itself.

What I find particularly interesting when I revisit this work today is that the framework did not stop with strategic initiatives.

It recognised that execution ultimately depends upon behaviour.

Alongside the strategic priorities sat a series of behavioural foundations—teamwork, commitment, open communication, player development and leadership development—that reflected the kind of organisational culture required to sustain the strategy over time. The committee also recognised that implementation demanded clarity of roles, agreed objectives, mutual accountability and disciplined follow-through. Success would depend not simply upon having the right initiatives, but upon creating a leadership team capable of working together in fundamentally different ways.

Looking back, I believe this was one of the strengths of the engagement.

Even before my later research into organisational transformation, we instinctively understood that strategy could not exist independently of leadership behaviour. A strategic framework is only as effective as the people responsible for bringing it to life. Objectives, metrics and action plans undoubtedly provide direction, but they cannot substitute for commitment, trust and collective purpose. Without those qualities, even the most carefully designed strategy gradually becomes another document stored on a shelf rather than a living guide to organisational decision-making.

Yet with the benefit of hindsight, I can also see something that we did not fully appreciate at the time.



We had built an excellent blueprint for organisational execution.

What we had not yet understood was how differently individual leaders might interpret that blueprint.

The framework clearly articulated what needed to be achieved. It defined priorities, clarified responsibilities and established the behavioural expectations that would support implementation. What it could not tell us was whether every member of the committee saw the future in the same way. Did they all attach the same meaning to the club's renewed vision? Did they share the same sense of responsibility for bringing it into existence? Did they all believe they possessed the influence necessary to make it succeed?

At the time, these questions remained largely unasked.

They would not emerge until years later, during my doctoral research into strategic transformation. It was only then that I began to understand that strategy is never implemented exactly as it is written. Before it becomes action, it is interpreted. And it is within that interpretive process that the seeds of both successful transformation and strategic failure are often sown.

Beyond Strategy: Aligning Executive Worldviews

Looking back at this engagement nearly two decades later, I remain convinced that the strategic framework was sound.

It began with an understanding of the changing competitive environment rather than organisational introspection. It recognised that strategy should emerge from a clear appreciation of the broader ecosystem within which the club operated. It articulated a compelling vision, clarified the club's value proposition, identified the strategic initiatives that would differentiate the organisation and translated those initiatives into practical action plans supported by measurable outcomes. Most importantly, it recognised that leadership behaviour was as important as strategic intent in determining whether the framework would ultimately succeed.

Today, however, I would add another layer to that process.

The years that followed this engagement—including consulting across Africa and the Middle East, and ultimately my doctoral research into strategic transformation—have fundamentally changed



the way I think about strategy execution. If this project taught me that organisations must first redefine the playing field before they develop strategy, my later research taught me that leadership teams must also develop a shared understanding of that playing field before they can execute it effectively.

In other words, strategic alignment is not only an organisational achievement.

It is an interpretive achievement.

When committees gather to formulate strategy, there is often an implicit assumption that everyone around the table understands the organisation's future in broadly the same way. They have reviewed the same environmental analysis, participated in the same workshops and agreed to the same strategic priorities. Consensus is therefore assumed to exist.

Experience suggests otherwise.

Senior leaders frequently leave the same strategic planning session with remarkably different understandings of what has actually been agreed. One committee member may interpret the renewed vision as an ambitious growth agenda. Another may view it primarily as a programme of organisational consolidation. One sees commercial expansion as the priority. Another believes community engagement should remain the defining purpose of the organisation. Both support the strategy. Both commit to its implementation. Yet they begin implementing two subtly different futures.

The strategic framework itself has not failed.

The interpretations of that framework have begun to diverge.

This is precisely where I would introduce the Worldview LOA today.

Before the committee developed strategic priorities, I would seek to understand how its members were interpreting the future they were about to create. Rather than beginning with strategic objectives, I would begin with three conversations that have become central to my own consulting practice.

The first concerns legitimacy. Does the leadership team genuinely believe that the proposed future represents the right direction for the organisation? This is not simply agreement with the business



case or the financial projections. It is a deeper judgement about whether the strategy is consistent with the organisation's identity, purpose and values. Unless leaders perceive the future as legitimate, commitment remains fragile regardless of how compelling the strategic analysis may appear.

The second concerns relational obligation. Strategic planning often assigns responsibilities, but responsibility is not the same as ownership. The more important question is whether leaders experience a genuine sense of stewardship towards the future they are designing. Do they feel personally accountable for its success? Do they regard themselves as custodians of something larger than their individual portfolios? When that sense of obligation is absent, strategy frequently becomes an exercise in coordination rather than collective leadership.

The third concerns agency. Even when leaders believe in the strategy and feel responsible for its success, they may still question whether they possess sufficient influence to make a meaningful contribution. Organisational history, governance arrangements and previous experiences of change all shape whether executives believe their actions will matter. Where agency is weak, commitment often gives way to cautious compliance. Where it is strong, leaders become active architects of transformation rather than passive participants.

What makes these three dimensions so powerful is that they are rarely discussed explicitly during strategic planning. Instead, they operate beneath the surface, quietly shaping how leaders interpret every strategic decision that follows. Two executives may endorse exactly the same strategic framework while holding very different assumptions about its legitimacy, their obligation to champion it and their capacity to influence its success. Those differences inevitably become visible during implementation.

If I were facilitating this engagement today, I would therefore begin with executive judgement before moving to strategic judgement.

Only once the committee had developed a shared understanding of why the future mattered, what responsibilities it created and how each member could contribute would we begin designing the strategic framework itself. The strategy would undoubtedly look similar. The conversations that produced it would be profoundly different.



This, perhaps, is the most important lesson I have learned since that engagement in the Arabian Gulf.

Great strategy does not begin with objectives.

It begins with perspective.

The organisations that consistently outperform their peers are rarely those that produce the most sophisticated strategic plans. They are the ones whose leaders first develop a shared understanding of the world they are trying to change. When executive judgement converges around a common view of legitimacy, responsibility and possibility, strategic alignment becomes more than organisational coordination. It becomes collective conviction.

That is why I have come to believe that the future of strategic planning lies not simply in producing better strategies, but in cultivating the executive worldviews through which those strategies are understood, owned and ultimately brought to life.